



SOUBEL COMMERCIAL GROWTH PLAYBOOK SYSTEM

From Market Signal to Revenue

A Commercial Growth & Go-to-Market Playbook
for Industrial Markets

The SOUBEL Commercial Growth Playbook System

Three companion playbooks. One operating philosophy. The system moves from establishing commercial reality, to proving opportunity, to building the enterprise capable of carrying greater ambition.

PLAYBOOK 02 OF 3

PROVE THE OPPORTUNITY

What opportunity has earned the right to become a revenue commitment?

Operational Trust™ = the evidence, economics, decision logic, execution capability, and learning remain connected as commitment increases.

System shorthand: Ambition creates possibility. Evidence earns commitment. Execution creates proof. Repeatability earns scale.

WHERE THIS PLAYBOOK FITS

1 ESTABLISH REALITY	2 PROVE THE OPPORTUNITY	3 EARN THE RIGHT TO SCALE
The First 90 Days Learn the business, test inherited assumptions, and build a defensible fact base.	From Market Signal to Revenue Convert market evidence into qualified commercial plays and durable revenue.	SOUBEL SCALE™ Govern progressively larger growth commitments and build the enterprise behind the ambition.

The Premise

A SIGNAL EARNS INVESTIGATION, NOT INVESTMENT.

Commercial growth begins when something observable suggests a customer problem, buying shift, value pool, installed-base gap, channel opening, or market change may be worth pursuing. Operational Trust requires the organization to strengthen the evidence before it strengthens the commitment.

Industrial markets are especially unforgiving of generic growth logic. Long capital and maintenance cycles, engineering-led buying cultures, technical qualification, shutdown or turnaround windows, complex distributor and dealer networks, installed-base realities, regulation, delivery capacity, working capital, and pricing can all determine whether a market that looks attractive from a distance can actually become durable revenue.

1. Start with the Signal

Signals can emerge from customers, field evidence, regulation, technology, competitors, capital cycles, installed-base behavior, pricing pressure, service failures, or patterns of no-decision. The first discipline is to state the signal without immediately turning it into a solution.

SIGNAL TYPE	EXAMPLES	FIRST QUESTION
Customer / operating	Repeated customer request, unresolved operating problem, recurring failure mode, workflow friction.	Is the consequence important enough that someone will act?
Market / regulatory	Rule change, inspection focus, capital-cycle shift, industry consolidation, new asset class.	Does this change buying behavior, timing, or risk tolerance?
Competitive	Competitor win pattern, acquisition, withdrawal, pricing shift, new commercial model.	What customer choice is changing and why?
Technology / capability	Technical differentiation with low adoption, new digital capability, underused service, new data source.	What decision becomes better, safer, faster, or more economic because this exists?
Portfolio / installed base	Low attach rate, dormant accounts, low cross-sell, underpenetrated geography, channel white space.	Is there a real customer need behind the theoretical whitespace?

2. Pass the Opportunity Reality Gate

Before the organization builds a campaign, hires coverage, launches a pilot, or assigns a quota, prove there is something worth capturing.

REALITY TEST	QUESTION	STRONGER EVIDENCE LOOKS LIKE
Consequence	What happens if the customer does nothing?	Observed operating impact, budget exposure, risk consequence, missed output, cost, delay, or strategic priority.

REALITY TEST	QUESTION	STRONGER EVIDENCE LOOKS LIKE
Trigger	Why now?	Event, deadline, failure, budget cycle, regulation, leadership mandate, asset change, or performance threshold.
Decision owner	Who must decide and who bears the consequence?	Named operational, technical, economic, regulatory, or executive ownership.
Funding path	How could this be paid for?	Budget, project, OPEX, CAPEX, contract vehicle, savings pool, or reprioritization mechanism.
Right-to-win	Why this organization?	Access, proof, trusted relationship, differentiated capability, footprint, economics, data, or partner advantage.
Delivery path	Can the promise be delivered reliably?	Qualified technical capacity, implementation path, supply/service readiness, and support model.

3. Diagnose the Growth System

A weak revenue result can come from three very different systems. Diagnose before prescribing.

LENS	TYPICAL FAILURE	EXAMPLES
Commercial	Demand or capability is not converting into profitable revenue.	Poor qualification, weak account penetration, pricing leakage, thin access, low conversion, channel inactivity.
Competitive	The customer is choosing a different answer.	Stronger incumbent position, lower switching friction elsewhere, better proof, different buying criteria, or doing nothing.
Operational	The organization cannot fully deliver the commercial promise.	Engineering or technical-review bottlenecks, plant / fabrication / field capacity, supply constraints, lead time, shutdown windows, quality, implementation, qualification, service support, or working capital.

4. Segment by Problem, Economics, and Customer Value

Segmentation is only useful when it changes resource allocation. Industry code, company size, or geography may describe the market without explaining where value is concentrated.

- Segment by customer problem and consequence: which problems are urgent, expensive, risky, or strategically important?
- Segment by customer economics: which relationships can create durable revenue and margin relative to cost-to-serve?
- Segment by buying behavior: what evidence, stakeholders, timing, and contracting path define how the customer buys?
- Segment by right-to-win: where does the organization already have access, trust, proof, installed base, footprint, or a credible path to create advantage?

- Segment by delivery fit: which opportunities align with scarce technical and operating capacity, and which would consume the system without adequate return?

5. Define the Customer Decision Before the Offer

1. What is happening?
2. Why does it matter?
3. What decision must the customer make?
4. What uncertainty prevents that decision?
5. What evidence would increase confidence?
6. Who owns the operational, economic, technical, or regulatory consequence?
7. What happens if nothing changes?
8. What capability can credibly reduce the uncertainty or consequence?

VALUE PROPOSITION RULE

The offer enters after the decision is understood. A value proposition is stronger when it explains how the customer decision, outcome, risk, economics, or confidence changes, not merely what features the seller provides.

6. Differentiation Has to Matter

TEST	QUESTION
Objective difference	What is actually different?
Customer relevance	For which problem does that difference matter?
Observability	Can the customer see, verify, or experience it?
Consequence	Does it change risk, outcome, speed, lifecycle cost, revenue, or decision confidence?
Value capture	Is the difference material enough to support price, share, switching, or retention?
Repeatability	Can delivery reproduce the claimed advantage consistently?

7. Strategic Accounts: Grow Earned Trust

Strategic-account growth begins with current value and trusted delivery, not a theoretical whitespace diagram. The account plan should show where the organization is already credible and where it has earned permission to expand.

- Map current revenue, margin, renewal/retention, and service burden by capability before estimating whitespace.
- Map the problems for which the customer already trusts the organization.
- Map the buying system, decision pathways, and operating units, not only the org chart.
- Identify adjacent customer decisions and value pools, not merely adjacent products.
- Use delivery performance, references, and resolved problems as commercial evidence.
- Prioritize account investment where customer value, relationship depth, right-to-win, and credible expansion intersect.

8. New Logos and New Markets: Build the Right to Win

A large addressable market is not a commercial plan. New-logo and new-market growth should be designed around buying triggers, engineering and vendor qualification, access, proof, switching conditions, budget and capital timing, outage or installation windows, economics, delivery footprint, and the specific advantage that can be built.

QUESTION	WHY IT MATTERS
What problem is underserved?	Demand must be tied to consequence, not market size alone.
What triggers action?	Timing matters as much as need.
What incumbent advantage must be overcome?	Installed base, contract, trust, data, footprint, or switching cost may dominate.
What proof earns consideration?	New entrants usually need stronger evidence than incumbents.
What access model works?	Direct, channel, alliance, OEM, digital, or hybrid routes create different economics and control.
Can delivery support the promise?	A sales win without operating readiness can destroy the market entry.

9. Analyze the Customer's Choice

Competitive analysis should explain the decision the customer is making, including the option to do nothing or solve the problem internally. Competitor feature tables are secondary.

- What alternatives are actually in the choice set?
- What does each alternative make easier, safer, cheaper, faster, or less disruptive?
- Where does an incumbent possess structural advantage: access, footprint, contract, switching cost, data, installed base, or trust?
- Where can the organization create a different basis of choice rather than imitate the incumbent?
- What evidence would make the customer reconsider the current answer?

10. Quantify Value and Capture It

Value quantification makes the customer consequence and the seller's assumptions inspectable. Pricing determines how much of that value the commercial model can retain. The two belong together.

VALUE SOURCE	EXAMPLES OF EVIDENCE
Revenue / throughput	Output protected or created, utilization restored, product availability, capacity released.
Cost / productivity	Labor burden, inspection cost, maintenance burden, rework, quality loss, material use.
Capital	Capital deferred, optimized, avoided, accelerated, or redeployed.
Risk / assurance	Probability or consequence reduced, without presenting avoided risk as guaranteed savings.

VALUE SOURCE	EXAMPLES OF EVIDENCE
Decision speed	Cycle time reduced, uncertainty removed, evidence produced sooner.
Lifecycle value	Reliability, service life, retention, renewal, recurring value, or total cost of ownership.

PRICING DISCIPLINE

Do not ask only, “What will the customer pay?” Ask what value is being created, how the customer compares alternatives, what the route-to-market costs, what margin and service burden the opportunity carries, and whether the price supports the model at scale.

11. Proof, Pilots, and Adoption

Design proof backward from the decision it must unlock. A pilot is useful only when success, failure, required evidence, customer decision, ownership, and next commercial step are defined before the work begins.

PROOF STAGE	EVIDENCE QUESTION
Problem	Did we verify the problem and consequence?
Solution / technical	Did the capability produce the required technical or operating outcome?
Economic	Did the outcome create enough value to support adoption and price?
Buying	Did the right stakeholders, budget path, procurement path, and decision timing emerge?
Adoption	Can the customer implement, repeat, and sustain the solution?
Retention / expansion	Does delivered value persist strongly enough to support renewal, repeat use, or broader adoption?

12. Channels and Routes to Market

Coverage changes economics, control, customer evidence, and execution. A channel is not successful because it exists. It is successful when it creates access, demand, capability, or economic value the organization can see and sustain.

CHANNEL QUESTION	WHAT TO MAKE EXPLICIT
Role	What customer, geography, use case, buying path, or service requirement does the distributor, dealer, representative, alliance, or other partner own or influence?
Economics	Discount, margin, rebate, inventory, cost-to-serve, working capital, and price realization.

CHANNEL QUESTION	WHAT TO MAKE EXPLICIT
Activation	Named sellers, enablement, target accounts, technical support, marketing, joint activity.
Governance	Account ownership, project protection, conflict resolution, direct/indirect rules, data expectations.
Evidence	Sell-in and sell-through where available, gross-margin contribution, price realization, inventory behavior, seller activation, pipeline quality, forecast accuracy, win/loss, account coverage, customer feedback, technical capability, and productivity.

13. Pipeline and Revenue Forecast Integrity

A HEALTHY PIPELINE IS EVIDENCE OF QUALIFIED MOVEMENT.

Pipeline volume should not be confused with revenue confidence. A CRM probability percentage is not customer evidence. Forecast confidence should rise as buying progress, price, technical qualification, delivery readiness, decision timing, and observable customer actions become visible.

FIELD	EVIDENCE TO PRESERVE
Customer problem / consequence	What is happening and why it matters.
Trigger	Why the decision moves now.
Buying path	Stakeholders, budget, procurement, technical validation, decision sequence.
Value / price	Economic consequence, offer value, price logic, margin / cost-to-serve.
Right-to-win	Why this seller can win against alternatives including no decision.
Delivery	Capacity, lead time, technical resources, implementation, dependencies.
Next customer action	Observable movement, not seller activity.
Forecast confidence	Committed / Probable / Developmental / Speculative, with reasons.

14. Design Reporting Backward from the Decision

Commercial reporting should begin with the decision leadership needs to make, then identify the evidence required to support it. Dashboards and visualizations are useful only when they preserve the definitions, sources, assumptions, and operating context behind the measures.

INFORMATION TRUST RULE

A metric earns trust when its definition, source, assumptions, and decision use remain connected.

DECISION	EVIDENCE REQUIRED	DEFINITION / SOURCE DISCIPLINE	ACTION WHEN SIGNAL CHANGES
Strategic-account investment	Customer value, margin, relationship depth, delivery trust, whitespace evidence, buying-path movement.	Common account definitions; authoritative revenue and margin sources; explicit whitespace assumptions.	Protect, reactivate, pursue, defer, or change resource level.
Channel investment	Partner revenue and margin, price realization, inventory, seller activation, opportunity creation, forecast quality, account coverage.	Define sell-in / sell-through logic where available; standard partner and territory definitions; visible missing data.	Enable, expand, correct, condition, redesign, or exit.
Pricing / value	Value case, price realization, discounting, cost-to-serve, competitive context, margin impact.	Link commercial price data to financial outcome and customer value assumptions.	Hold, reprice, redesign scope, or change commercial model.
Forecast / capacity	Customer evidence, stage criteria, timing, delivery dependencies, backlog, technical capacity.	Stage and forecast classes must mean the same thing across teams and routes to market.	Commit resources, qualify risk, resequence, or remove from forecast.
Market / portfolio choice	Demand signal, customer concentration, economics, right-to-win, delivery readiness.	Use repeatable definitions and traceable sources so markets and opportunities can be compared rather than merely described.	Advance, test, hold, redesign, stop, or hand off to SCALE.

Business intelligence can provide the evidence infrastructure, but commercial leadership still has to define the questions, measures, thresholds, and actions. The useful sequence is business question -> required evidence -> authoritative source -> standardized definition -> analysis -> decision -> action -> measured outcome.

15. The Revenue Opportunity Map

The Revenue Opportunity Map is the synthesis layer. It preserves what the opportunity is, why it may exist, what evidence supports it, what it may be worth, why the organization could win, what could prevent capture, and what decision follows. It is deliberately not a chain of arrows or a dashboard of unsupported numbers.

FIELD	WHAT IT HOLDS
Opportunity / segment	Customer problem, segment, account or market.
Evidence	What is known, assumed, unknown, or disconfirmed.
Economic range	Value pool, plausible capture, margin, price, cost-to-serve, investment.
Right-to-win	Access, proof, differentiation, trust, footprint, partner or capability.
Buying path	Decision owners, funding, proof, procurement, timing.
Delivery / adoption	Capacity, implementation, customer readiness, post-sale requirements.
Decision	Advance, test, hold, redesign, stop, or hand off to SCALE.
Owner / cadence	Who owns the next evidence and when the decision is revisited.

16. Commercial Governance

- Review validated growth gaps, not just forecast totals.
- Review account portfolio by Protect / Reactivate / Pursue / Defer and customer value.
- Review win, loss, and no-decision learning.
- Allocate commercial and technical resources against evidence-backed priorities.
- Review price realization, margin, cost-to-serve, and value capture.
- Review delivery capacity, backlog, implementation, and technical constraints.
- Review the health of the commercial information system: shared definitions, authoritative sources, reporting latency, data gaps, and manual reconciliation that can distort decisions.
- Maintain a decision log: what changed, why, what evidence drove the change, and what would change it again.
- Refresh the Revenue Opportunity Map on a defined cadence.

Workbook: Commercial Validation Pack

Market Signal Brief

SIGNAL	CUSTOMER CONSEQUENCE	WHAT MUST BE TRUE	CURRENT EVIDENCE	NEXT TEST	OWNER

Customer Decision Map

DECISION	OWNER / INFLUENCER	UNCERTAINTY	EVIDENCE REQUIRED	WHAT HAPPENS IF NO ACTION

Value & Pricing Case

VALUE SOURCE	BASELINE	EXPECTED RANGE	ASSUMPTIONS	PRICE / COMMERCIAL IMPLICATION

Value Source	Baseline	Expected Range	Assumptions	Price / Commercial Implication

Forecast Evidence Table

Opportunity	Forecast Class	Customer Evidence	Open Dependencies	Next Customer Action	Timing Risk

Commercial Metric Dictionary

Metric	Business Definition	Authoritative Source	Owner / Cadence	Decision / Threshold

The Final Commercial Test

1. What is changing in the market or customer environment?
2. Which customer problems are important enough to fund?
3. Which customers and segments create disproportionate value?
4. Where does the organization have, or can it build, a credible right-to-win?
5. What evidence supports each opportunity and how strong is it?
6. What is the economic consequence and value case?

7. What price and route-to-market preserve viable economics?
8. What buying path must be navigated?
9. What technical and delivery capability must be mobilized?
10. What binding constraint threatens capture or adoption?
11. What should be stopped or deprioritized?
12. Are the critical metrics behind the decision consistently defined, traceable to authoritative sources, and tied to action?
13. What will be measured after commitment?
14. What evidence would cause the strategy to change?

Handoff to SOUBEL SCALE

WHAT THIS PLAYBOOK PRODUCES

Validated commercial plays with customer evidence, economics, price/value logic, right-to-win, buying path, route-to-market, adoption requirements, delivery dependencies, and the measurement logic required to govern the play. SCALE does not repeat this analysis. It asks which validated plays materially advance the ambition, compete well for scarce enterprise resources, and deserve progressively larger commitment.

Selected Comparative Context

SOUBEL uses external strategy, growth, marketing, finance, and scaling literature as comparative context rather than as a substitute for its own operating architecture. The sources below informed questions, stress tests, and terminology choices. No external framework is reproduced as the SOUBEL method.

Wharton Executive Education, Scaling Business for Profitable Growth. Cross-functional scale readiness across strategy, finance, marketing, leadership, KPIs, capital, people, processes, and execution. [Source](#)

Wharton Executive Education, Chief Revenue Officer Program. Revenue as a cross-functional system spanning sales, marketing, customer management, pricing, and revenue operations. [Source](#)

Wharton / Peter Fader, Managing the Value of Customer Relationships. Customer heterogeneity, customer value, segmentation, and resource concentration on economically important relationships. [Source](#)

Wharton Executive Education, Pricing Strategies. Pricing as a strategic value-capture and profitability decision rather than an afterthought. [Source](#)

Kellogg Executive Education, High-Impact Sales Strategy. Segmentation, value propositions, integrated go-to-market design, channel mix, key accounts, customer engagement, and execution. [Source](#)

Kellogg Executive Education, Business Marketing Strategy. B2B segmentation, targeting, positioning, customer value, account-based approaches, customer success, and loyalty. [Source](#)

Kellogg Executive Education, B2B Sales Force Strategy & Effectiveness. Sales structure, territory, strategic accounts, sales operations, CRM, analytics, AI, and change roadmaps. [Source](#)

Roger L. Martin, Strategy. Strategy as a set of interrelated choices about aspiration, where to play, how to win, capabilities, and management systems. [Source](#)

Rita McGrath and Ian MacMillan, Discovery-Driven Planning. Planning and control for uncertain new ventures, with learning and assumption testing before irreversible commitment. [Source](#)

Strategyzer, Testing Business Ideas. Explicit hypotheses, experiment design, evidence strength, and learning cycles before scale. [Source](#)

McKinsey & Company, Three Horizons of Growth. Concurrent attention to current performance, emerging growth businesses, and future options. [Source](#)

Dr. Benjamin Hardy and Blake Erickson, The Science of Scaling. Ambition-led scaling, simplification, elimination of what cannot scale, and designing the system from the future state backward. [Source](#)

ABOUT THIS WORK

Developed by Helen M. Dupree for SOUBEL.

Part of the SOUBEL Commercial Growth Playbook System. SOUBEL SCALE[™] and Operational Trust[™] are marks of SOUBEL. soubel.com